

every business. For the businessman—as for any individual—the true test of his mettle comes at the time when he is faced with adversity.

How do executives or businessmen act and react when they are at bay?

First, there are those who sit by helplessly, allowing whatever adversity they face to overwhelm them completely.

They are like rabbits which, transfixed by the headlights of an automobile rushing toward them on a highway, make no move to save themselves and are consequently crushed under the vehicle's wheels. Such men take no action to change the course of events and prevent disaster because they are incapable of comprehending what could or might be done. When they have been finally overwhelmed, they are stunned, totally unable to understand what went wrong and why.

Then, there are those who surrender meekly or flee in fear as soon as things start to go wrong. Such men have little or no sense of proportion; they are likely to panic and view even minor slumps and setbacks as unavoidable major catastrophes. While individuals in the first category fail to fight back because they do not know how to fight, businessmen who can be classed in this second group fail to fight back because they are afraid to do so.

125

Next come those men who react to adversity in an unreasonable, almost hysterical fashion. Terror-stricken, they snarl and snap, striking back blindly and ineffectually, squandering their energies in the wrong directions. These men invariably rail and curse against the "impossible odds"

and "rotten breaks" they claim defeated them. Just as invariably, they seek to lay the blame for the predicaments in which they find themselves on shoulders other than their own.

In another category are those businessmen who fight good, tenacious—and, very frequently, entirely successful

—defensive actions whenever things start to go wrong.